



Teaching Statement

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As an instructor of economics, I believe that my primary responsibility is to cultivate genuine curiosity and love for the discipline in my students. This is not to say that performance is unimportant, but that it is a byproduct for any student who is genuinely curious about the content they are learning. Economics is, after all, a beautiful discipline that provides a framework for understanding the world around us – one that is not easily learned by memorizing formulas or definitions. By instilling a sense of curiosity within a student, I believe they self motivate to learn not just the material presented in front of them, but the way of thinking that is required for further success in both classes to come and all other pursuits.

This is not an easy achievement. Within a single classroom, there are those who come in already curious, eager to learn more about a passion they already possess, and those who come in not yet so, eager only to fulfill a requirement for graduation. Optimal treatment for these types of students should, in my experience, differ because *initializing* a sense of curiosity is not the same as *retaining* one.

Students who enter the class in need of inspiration respond best when the content is brought to them. Discussions within the classroom, examples, and even practice problems should reflect the interests of the students in question. Not only does this provide an incentive to simply pay attention, but, perhaps more importantly, it creates a link between economics and something they are already connected with. [STATEMENT ABOUT HOW THIS BEGINS A PASSION FOR ECONOMICS].

On the other hand, there are always a select few who come into the class with an already existing passion. Such students do not need help developing a connection to economics. On the contrary, I find that time spent on such efforts serve only to bore the student and, in the worst case, this boredom will squash any pre-existing interest. These students need to be challenged. Discussions, examples, and practice problems should be sufficiently nuanced such that it expands their understanding of the underlying theory. [STATEMENT ABOUT HOW THIS LEAVES BEHIND THE STUDENTS WHO NEED TO ESTABLISH A CONNECTION].

Therefore, if any educator desires to benefit both types of students, which I believe we all should, it is imperative to very early identify which students need which instruction. In my own experience, I have attempted to address this challenge with a pre-semester survey. Within it, students were asked about their relationship to economics, their reasons for enrolling, and the fields they study outside of my own classroom. I found this to be initially beneficial, as it provided me with an early and practical map of my students – who needed a bridge connecting them to the material, and who needed to be pushed further within it. Well intentioned as this was, I do not believe it was perfect. As the semester carried on, I found that my students grew rapidly across this dimension. Students who began the class needing a spark brought in, and with that, their experience from me needed to change accordingly. This taught me an ironic lesson. While it is my duty to teach, to do so effectively, I as the educator need to both study my students in preparation for the class and to be diligent in continued study as the class progressed. Actively doing so, and adjusting the classroom along with it, is what is required of a teacher to achieve the gold-standard goal of curiosity.